



Staying connected

Browsers that will let you get your daily dose of the net, on your mobile...

Agent 001

A few years ago, WAP (wireless application protocol) was considered a luxury, and a lot of us had the “My service provider’s cooler than yours,” arguments, based solely on the cost of internet access. I was, at one point, paying Rs 499 per month to get internet access on my phone. When it comes to electronics and technology, the meek mobile phone has inherited the Earth. With a rather large percentage of people owning one, it’s obvious to everyone that networking the world is easiest achieved through mobile devices. Unfortunately, things aren’t as simple as hooking everyone up with a mobile internet connection.

We have the goal – connect the world; get them on the net. We have the technology: GPRS, EDGE, 3G, Wi-Fi, etc. However, as is usually the case, software plays spoilsport.

Just browsing

No two phone manufacturers seem to agree on any one browser. Although it may not seem like a problem, it actually wouldn’t hurt for someone to have a Microsoft-like strangle-hold on mobile browsers – the way IE is on the desktop. Before you gawk in disbelief at that statement, finish reading the article and perhaps it will begin to make sense.

Basically, there is a need for standards, as the lack of them is confusing everyone – you, me, developers, mobile manufacturers, ISPs; effectively chucking a rather large spanner in the works.

Order to chaos

Thankfully, the W3C (World Wide Web Consortium, founded by Tim Berners-Lee) is trying to set some standards here, and ensure that we all have similar experiences when browsing the mobile web, no matter what handsets we use.

Wouldn’t it be nice to be able to browse the mobile web the same way we do on our desktops? Barring a few sites that are “optimised” for Internet Explorer, the “desktop web”, is basically standardised. When it comes to mobile browsers, however, the reality is quite the opposite.

Apart from the W3C, the Web Standards project is also involved in creating tests that browsers (especially mobile browsers) need to pass before they can claim to conform to standards. More information in the box “Acid3 test”.



“The Mobile Web Initiative’s goal is to make browsing the Web from mobile devices a reality. W3C and mobile industry leaders are working together to improve Web content production and access for mobile users and the greater Web.”

Tim Berners-Lee

Internet Inventor / W3C Director
www.w3.org

Mobile Browsers

Let’s take a look at what’s on offer for those of you who can’t wait to get online from your mobiles.

Android

Google’s open source initiative brought us the Android mobile OS, and although there aren’t too many devices that run it just yet, you can count on Google’s past success in everything they do to ensure that this will change soon. Android’s browser has got some rave reviews from early adopters. It uses the WebKit rendering engine, which is basically an API that Apple derived from the KHTML software library that is used in KDE’s Konqueror browser. The browser is fast, renders well, and with WebKit promising to be one of the few to pass the Acid3 test soon, there are certainly not going to be too many formatting errors. The android browser scores 72/100 in the Acid3 test.



Acid3 test



The Web Standards Project has a battery of tests to verify how a browser follows the accepted web standards, and how a browser displays them. Standards are important for the web, and the WSP is doing its bit to try and get all major browsers to conform to set guidelines. Even those of you who use a desktop to surf the net will have come across some site or the other that just breaks when you view it – with text that refuses to stay in its box, images that refuse to resize right, or menus that seem to act all crazy. Sometimes it’s the site’s coder who have screwed up, but sometimes, it’s your browser that’s coughed and died, because it just doesn’t support a certain web standard. If everyone followed standards, you could just use your favourite browser, visit any site, and never have to see terribly broken layouts or renders. The Acid3 test is supposed to tell you whether your browser is following the coding rules, or not. Anyone can run the Acid3 test by visiting <http://acid3.acidtests.org>. More information on the various Acid tests are available at www.webstandards.org.

Scoring (desktop browsers):

IE7: 12/100

IE8: 21/100

Firefox 3.03: 71/100

Opera 9.63: 85/100

Google Chrome / Safari 3.2: 75/100

Interestingly, newer versions of both WebKit and Presto (that’s Safari/Chrome and Opera to regular folk) pass the Acid3 test with flying colours, and although IE8 has improved on IE7s scores, it’s still pathetically placed. Now if someone could only get Microsoft’s IE team to start caring, we’d hope to see some improvements in that score.